CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

APPLIANCE REPAIR TECH IN THE AI ERA

The washer dies full of water, the fridge warms up before a party — and almost nobody under 40 knows how to fix either. That gap is a business.

★ TL;DR — Median around $75K for experienced techs and owners, enterable in 1–6 months with no license required in most places. The catch: sealed-system and electronics skills separate the pros — parts-swappers plateau, diagnosticians and owners take the money. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

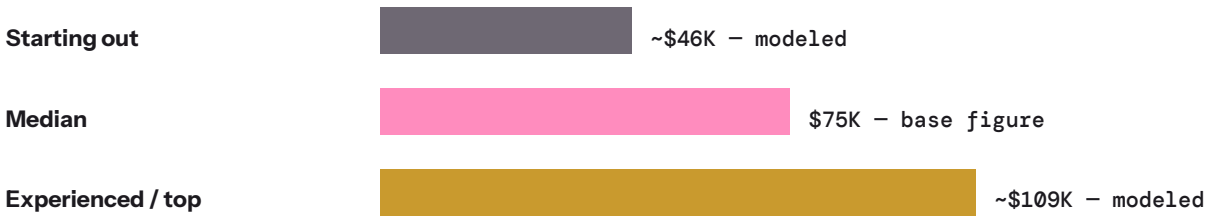
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

- Works because: homes are full of expensive appliances people repair before replacing, and manufacturers' service networks are thin and slow.
- Bites because: diagnosis across a dozen brands and a hundred models is a knowledge grind — every brand hides its service mode differently.
- AI angle: minimal. Error codes and YouTube help owners; control boards, sealed systems and intermittent faults still need a trained human in the kitchen.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Appliance Repair Tech is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A APPLIANCE REPAIR TECH ACTUALLY DO?

✓ Diagnose washers, dryers, fridges, ovens and dishwashers: interview the owner, run diagnostics, test components

✓ Replace motors, pumps, boards, elements, compressors' supporting parts — and know when repair stops making sense

✓ Handle refrigerant-adjacent work carefully within the rules, or refer sealed-system jobs appropriately

✓ Run a route: multiple homes a day, parts in the van, honest quotes at the kitchen table

Think: a house-call doctor for the machines a home runs on — symptoms, tests, a prognosis, and a price the patient approves before surgery.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Smart appliances self-report error codes and usage data, which helps triage. It does not disassemble a washer, find the chewed wire, or sweat a fitting in a cramped laundry closet.	Cross-brand diagnostic reasoning, intermittent faults (the dryer that only fails on Tuesdays), and the trust conversation: fix it for this much, or replace it — said honestly in someone's kitchen.

⚠ **Manufacturer authorization and warranty work have their own gatekeeping, and parts availability can strand a diagnosis. Also: solo techs live on reviews and response time — the trade is as much reputation logistics as repair.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ In and out of different homes all day — no two calls alike ✓ Hero economics: you arrive during a domestic crisis and leave a working home ✓ One of the cleanest one-person business setups in the trades	✗ Heavy machines in tight spaces; fridges do not move themselves ✗ Schedule chaos — emergency calls rearrange every day ✗ You carry the cost of wrong guesses when parts can't be returned

Good fit? You're a methodical troubleshooter who likes variety and people in small doses, and you're honest about fix-vs-replace even when fixing pays you more.
Bad fit? You want one machine to master forever, or you cut diagnostic corners. Appliance faults punish guessers with callbacks.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — TECH AT A REPAIR COMPANY	DOOR B — TRAINING COURSE → SOLO
Appliance repair companies hire trainees with mechanical/electrical aptitude and train brand by brand. You'll ride along, then run your own route — in 1–6 months you're solving real calls, with the brand knowledge compounding for years.	Appliance repair training programs (several run a few months) teach electrical theory, refrigeration basics and the major brands' systems — then launch your own service. Faster independence; the diagnostic depth must be self-built on real calls.

Smart move: Learn sealed-system/refrigeration properly and get EPA 608 if you pursue refrigerant work — few techs do, so fridge and freezer calls become your premium lane. Pair it with fast response: in this trade, 'tomorrow morning' beats 'cheapest' for most customers. Where you land after: Trainee → route tech → senior/brand specialist → your own repair company or manufacturer field service.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
BUILD ELECTRICAL	GET HIRED	RIDE ALONG,	MASTER THE	ADD THE	OWN THE

STEP 1 — Build electrical basics first

FREE-LOW · WEEKS

- Voltage, continuity, motors, switches, heating elements — the shared language of every appliance.
- A multimeter is your stethoscope; learn it before your first ride-along.

STEP 2 — Get hired or get trained

1-6 MO BAND

- Apply to repair companies as a trainee, or complete a structured appliance program.
- Either way: safety with capacitors, gas lines and water-plus-electricity is day-one material.

STEP 3 — Ride along, then run calls

PAID · MONTHS

- Learn each brand's diagnostic modes and common failures; keep a personal fault library with model numbers.
- Watch how senior techs quote at the table — that conversation is a skill, not a script.

STEP 4 — Master the big five categories

ONGOING

- Laundry, refrigeration, cooking, dishwashers, and the control boards that run them all.
- Intermittent faults: document conditions, don't guess — callbacks are unpaid tuition.

STEP 5 — Add the premium skills

MONTHS 4+

- Sealed-system theory and, for refrigerant handling, EPA 608 certification.
- Speed on first-visit fixes: stock the van with the parts your fault library says you'll need.

STEP 6 — Own the route or the company

YEAR 1+

- Solo route: business registration, insurance, booking software and a review engine.
- Or climb inside a company: senior tech, trainer, warranty/authorized-service specialist.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: list repair companies hiring trainees; buy a multimeter and learn it tonight.

□ Days 1–30: ride-alongs or coursework; electrical testing on every component you meet.

□ Days 31–60: first solo simple calls (elements, pumps, belts) with a senior tech a phone call away.

□ Days 61–90: build your fault library; start EPA 608 study if refrigeration is your lane.

□ Day 90: a working tech with real calls closed — this trade's ramp is genuinely this quick.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **DIAGNOSE FIRST. THE PART IS THE EASY BIT.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.